

Subject: Status update - Town Meeting Public Communications Channel

From: Stephen Harrington <sth.alist@gmail.com>

Date: 9/3/26, 12:52

To: John Hurd <JHurd@town.arlington.ma.us>, Jim Feeney
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Dear Select Board Chair John Hurd and Town Manager Jim Feeney,

I am following up to bring together several related matters concerning resident communications with Town Meeting that remain outstanding.

First, public records. My request for records of resident submissions rejected or otherwise not disseminated during the 2024 and 2025 Town Meetings remains outstanding. The supplemental 2026 production identified additional responsive records that were absent from the earlier production, but the requested 2024 and 2025 records have not yet been produced or otherwise accounted for.

Second, authority for the current rule. In his August 12 response, Mr. Feeney referred my questions concerning the legal authority for the resident co-signing requirement to Town Counsel. I have not yet received the Town's answer concerning the source and scope of that authority or the requested information concerning comparable practices in other Massachusetts communities.

Third, prospective remedy. I subsequently provided Chair Hurd and Mr. Feeney with a proposed neutral resident-access mechanism intended to move this discussion away from historical disputes and toward a workable prospective solution. I have not yet received a response concerning that proposal or whether the matter will be placed before the Select Board for public discussion.

These issues overlap, but they are distinct. The records request concerns the historical record; the Town Counsel questions concern the legal basis for the existing policy; and the proposed remedy concerns how the Town should proceed going forward.

I would appreciate a status update on each of these three matters, including what remains under review and the anticipated next step.

My preference remains to resolve the underlying resident-access issue prospectively and institutionally rather than continue debating individual past submissions. The proposed remedy was offered for that purpose, and I remain interested in any refinements the Town believes would make it workable.

Regards,
Stephen Harrington